The best part of the visit was watching Elton and David and their two boys fall in love with Archie. Often I'd catch Elton studying Archie's face and I knew what he was thinking: Mummy. I knew because it happened so often to me as well. Time and again I'd see an expression cross Archie's face and it would bring me up short. I nearly said so to Elton, how much I wished my mother could hold her grandson, how often it happened that, while hugging Archie, I felt her—or wanted to. Every hug tinged with nostalgia; every tuck-in touched with grief.

Does anything bring you face-to-face with the past like parenthood?

On the last night we were all experiencing that familiar end-of-holiday malaise: *Why can't it be like this forever?* We were drifting from the terrace to the pool, and back again, Elton offering cocktails, David and I chatting about the news. And the sorry state of the press. And what it meant for the state of Britain.

We got onto books. David mentioned Elton's memoir, at which he'd been toiling for years. It was finally done, and Elton was mighty proud of it, and the publication date was drawing near.

Bravo, Elton!

Elton mentioned that it was going to be serialized.

Is that so?

Yes. Daily Mail.

He saw my face. He quickly looked away.

Elton, how in the absolute—?

I want people to read it!

But, Elton—? The very people who've made your life miserable?

Exactly. Who better to excerpt it? Where better than the very newspaper that's been so poisonous to me my whole life?

Who better? I just…I don't understand.

It was a warm night, so I'd already been sweating. But now beads were dripping off my forehead. I reminded him of the specific lies the *Mail* had famously printed about him. Hell—he'd sued them, just over a decade earlier, after they claimed he forbade people at a charity event from speaking to him.

They'd ultimately written him a check for a hundred thousand pounds.